



Central and Local Government Relations

Masatsugu Ito

3.1 INTRODUCTION

The aim of this chapter is to clarify the characteristics of the relationship between the central and local governments in Japan in the context of international comparisons and historical developments as well as to provide an overview of the impact of decentralization reforms that have been taking place since the 1990s and a perspective on the future.

The modern system of local governments in Japan comprises two tiers of local government: municipalities as basic local governmental units and prefectures as wide-area local governmental units.¹ This two-tier system has been maintained for about a century since the 1921 abolition of counties that encompassed municipalities.

In this way, Japan as a unitary state applies a uniform two-tier system to the entire country. At the same time, there is a special system that is applied to metropolitan areas that are home to large concentrations of population. This special system for metropolitan areas encompasses a system that is based on two different ideas that emerged due to historical reasons.

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First, the system is one that is based on the notion of transferring some of the authority vested in prefectural governments to the local autonomous bodies (local governments) of large cities to give these local autonomous bodies greater authority than other municipalities. The current Local Autonomy Act sets forth a system of government ordinance-designated cities and core cities. Authority over administrative affairs related to child welfare, urban planning, environmental preservation, and more is transferred from the prefectural government to each government ordinance-designated city with a population of at least 500,000 people designated by a Cabinet order. In addition, while authority over administrative affairs related to health, sanitation, urban planning, and more is transferred from the prefectural government to each core city designated by a Cabinet order with a population of at least 200,000 people, the scope of this authority is more narrowly set than it is for government ordinance-designated cities. Twenty cities have been designated as government ordinance-designated cities while sixty-two cities, including prefectural capitals and cities located in metropolitan areas, have been designated as core cities (as of April 1, 2024).

Second, and in contrast, the metropolitan government system is a special system for the centralized management of metropolitan areas by a wide-area local autonomous body. Constituting a wide-area local autonomous body, a metropolitan government has special wards, which are basic local autonomous bodies. In areas where special wards are located, the metropolitan government is centrally in charge of firefighting, water supply, sewage treatment, transportation, and other such functions. The metropolitan government system can be traced to the establishment of the Tokyo Metropolitan Government in 1943 during the Second World War when the dual system consisting of the city of Tokyo and Tokyo Prefecture was overcome by combining these two entities in order to build a system for defending the capital. The metropolitan government system applies only to Tokyo and functions as a *de facto* system for the capital.

How can we characterize the relationship between the central and local governments in Japan, which are predicated on the existence of two-tier local governments and which include this special system for metropolitan areas? In order to clarify the characteristics of the relationship between the central and local governments of Japan in the context of international comparisons and historical development in this chapter, the author has set forth the following two perspectives.

The first is a multifaceted perspective on the relationship between the central and local governments. In general, the relationship between the central and local governments can be seen through the lenses of centralization and decentralization, but what this specifically means is ambiguous. Tulia G. Falleti compared the decentralization of power in various Latin American countries with respect to three aspects: administrative decentralization, fiscal decentralization, and political decentralization. Administrative decentralization refers to policies to transfer distributive authority related to education, welfare, housing, and other social services to local governments. Fiscal decentralization means policies to increase the revenue or fiscal authority of local governments. Political decentralization refers to electoral reforms and constitutional amendments that increase the political authority of local governmental entities and establish or expand the representative nature of local political entities (Falleti, 2010, pp. 33–39).

The second is a perspective that regards the relationship between the central and local governments through not just the lenses of centralization and decentralization but also the lenses of interfusion and separation. AMAKAWA Akira, who studied the reformation of Japan's local government system both after the Second World War and during the Occupation period, set forth the lenses of interfusion and separation from the perspective of the extent to which the central and local governments are able to play a part in providing administrative services at a local level (Amakawa, 1981).

Interfusion refers to circumstances wherein local governments are comprehensively responsible for the provision of administrative services at a local level, while the central government is able to be broadly involved in the execution of affairs by local governments. In general, with an interfused relationship between the central and local governments, the authority of local governments is explained with generalized examples, the role of local offices of the central government is limited, and local governments delegated by the central government provide a wide range of services. However, the central government is typically involved in matters related to standards and methods for the execution of affairs by local governments.

In contrast, separation refers to circumstances wherein there is a clear division of the roles and authority of the central and local governments with respect to the provision of administrative services. With a separation-type relationship between the central and local governments, local governments can only exercise authority as concerns matters for which authority

has been enumerated. Matters coming within the jurisdiction of the central government, even if they concern local administrative services, are carried out through local offices of the central government.

In general, interfusion applies to the relationship between the central and local governments throughout continental Europe while separation applies in Anglo-Saxon countries (Nishio, 2007). Given that Japan largely modernized by applying the German model of governance, the relationship between the central and local governments in this country is characterized by interfusion.

In this chapter, the historical development of the relationship between the central and local governments in Japan will be analyzed with respect to three aspects – public administration, finance, and politics – and how the relationship between the central and local governments in Japan, with its interfused character, came to be formed.

3.2 HISTORICAL CONSTRUCTION OF CENTRAL AND LOCAL GOVERNMENT RELATIONS IN MODERN JAPAN

3.2.1 *Construction of Modern State and Local Government Systems*

In Japan during the period extending from the seventeenth century to the middle of the nineteenth century, matters not coming under the direct control of the ruling Tokugawa family were governed with relative autonomy by each clan. However, the Tokugawa government came to be dissolved upon contact with Western nations. As the task of building a modern state came to be set with the Meiji Restoration (1868), the relationship between the central and local governments underwent fundamental changes.

In 1871, the Meiji government dissolved the clans that had existed until then and replaced them with new prefectural governments and appointed bureaucrats dispatched by the state as prefectural governors to thereby set up a centralized system of government. In 1888, a system in which municipalities, as basic local bodies, are placed in charge of education, tax collection, family registers, and other affairs required for the building of a modern state was developed. In addition, regulations governing prefectures and counties were put in place in 1890.

The local system that was developed during the Meiji Period had the following characteristics as seen with respect to the aspects of public administration, finance, and politics.

First, an interfused relationship between the central and local governments was established in terms of public administration. Since prefectural governors and head county officials were officials dispatched by the Home Ministry, prefectures and counties possessed a strong character as local general offices of the national government. On the other hand, municipalities were granted a certain degree of autonomy. For this reason, the government of the time adopted an agency-delegated function system under which mayors were regarded as subordinate organs of the state and made to execute affairs of the state accordingly in order to ensure that these affairs were executed at the local level. Conversely, the state positioned municipalities as comprehensive administrative entities that execute affairs of the state in addition to their own affairs. By establishing an interfused relationship between the central and local governments, the government established a system to ensure the implementation of state policy and public administration at a local level.

Second, the financial independence of local governments was restricted under the local system established during the Meiji Period. With prefectural taxation being legalized in 1878 and municipal taxation being legalized in 1888, prefectures and municipalities came to be entitled to levy and collect local taxes. However, most local taxes were surtaxes on national taxes and other such levies. On the other hand, costs related to compulsory education and other matters became a burden for smaller municipalities, such that the guaranteeing of financial resources appropriate for the delivery of administrative services in local areas became a challenge.

Third, elements of political decentralization were also recognized, albeit to a limited extent, under the local system established during the Meiji Period. Both prefectures and municipalities established their own assemblies. While the right to vote for the members of prefectural and municipal assemblies was limited in the beginning to men who had paid at least a certain amount of tax, the restriction based on the amount of tax paid was lifted in 1926. In addition, a system under which municipal assemblies elect mayors came to be established in 1926.

3.2.2 *Progress of "Functional Centralization"*

Thus, from the end of the nineteenth century to the beginning of the twentieth century, Japan came to establish a centralized local system especially in the aspects of public administration and finance in order to promote modernization. However, the relationship between the central and local governments changed as urbanization and industrialization took hold from the 1930s onward and as the country placed itself on a war footing from the 1940s onward.

First, in the area of public administration, the expansion and specialization of individual administrative functions caused ministries to establish and expand local offices, as a result of which the interfused character of the system became relatively weakened. The expansion of the functions of public administration in the area of rural public works and functions of sanitation and social administration as well as the increasing tendency of ministries to establish their own local offices upset the system under which the affairs of the central government and the affairs of the local government were implemented on an interfused basis through the channel of prefectures to municipalities.

Second, in the area of finance, a financial adjustment system was developed, and the link between central government finances and local government finances was strengthened. Beginning in the 1930s, the impact of the Great Depression plunged rural areas in Japan into hard times and placed the finances of towns and villages in dire straits. Thus, the amount of state subsidies allocated to local governments by individual ministries of the central government went up, and the introduction of a financial adjustment system to allocate a portion of national taxes according to the fiscal strength of local governments was studied. Consequently, a system for carrying out a partial tax transfer to local governments was established in 1940.

Third, political centralization occurred under the wartime regime. In 1943, the prefectural and municipal systems were amended, such that mayors of cities came to be appointed by the Home Ministry on the recommendation of the municipal assembly of each city, and mayors of towns and villages came to be elected by the municipal assembly of each town or village, subject to approval by the prefectural governor. With the abolition of the City of Tokyo under the Tokyo metropolitan government system that was enacted in the same year, the municipal assembly of the City of Tokyo was abolished, thereby setting back democracy in the capital.

These changes to the relationship between the central and local governments from the 1930s onward are known as *functional centralization* (Ichikawa, 2012). Accompanied by an expansion of the government's administrative and fiscal functions and a tightening of the relationship between the central and local governments, functional centralization formed a basis for the transition of Japan to a welfare state in the years following the Second World War. At the same time, institutional decentralization with respect to the aspects of public administration, finance, and politics was spearheaded by the General Headquarters for the Allied Forces (GHQ) in Japan after Japan was defeated in the Second World War. The relationship between the central and local governments in postwar Japan can be seen in terms of both functional centralization and institutional decentralization.

3.3 CONTINUITY AND CHANGE IN CENTRAL AND LOCAL GOVERNMENT RELATIONS IN POSTWAR JAPAN

3.3.1 *Decentralization in Occupied Japan*

After the Second World War, the relationship between the central and local governments changed substantially amid the democratization of Japan by the GHQ, which was in charge of the occupation of the country.

First, political decentralization progressed significantly. New provisions governing local autonomy were included in the Constitution of Japan, which came into force in 1947. Whereas prewar laws concerning the local system of government stipulated local entities on an individual basis, the Local Autonomy Act was likewise enacted in 1947 as a uniform code providing for local autonomy. The reformation of the local system as spearheaded by the GHQ led to the introduction of a system under which residents directly and publicly elect prefectural governors and municipal mayors as well as the recognition of women's suffrage in elections of the heads of local governments and members of local assemblies.

Second, administrative decentralization proceeded apace, and the authority of local governments was fortified. In particular, municipalities came to be the primary entities behind the establishment of junior high schools as an element of compulsory education under the Occupation-era reforms that were undertaken, and their authority was expanded as they took on affairs related to social welfare, health, and sanitation. In addition,

the Home Ministry, which had been in charge of controlling the thoughts of the people prior to the war, was dismantled at the behest of the GHQ in 1947, such that there was no ministry exercising overall control over local governments until 1960, when the Ministry of Home Affairs was established.²

Third, the authority of local autonomous bodies in fiscal matters was also fortified. The Local Tax Act was enacted in 1950, which abolished surtaxes on national taxes and expanded local tax revenues.

3.3.2 Sustaining an Interfused Relationship Between Central and Local Governments

Institutional reforms carried out thusly between the latter half of the 1940s and the first half of the 1950s helped promote local decentralization in Japan. If anything, however, decentralization accompanying the postwar reformation of the local system of government tended to work to strengthen the interfused character of the relationship between the central and local governments that had been in place since the Meiji Period.

First, as a paradoxical consequence of the decentralization of politics to the prefectures, prefectural governors came to be subject to the command and supervision of central government ministries through the system of agency-delegated functions. As mentioned earlier, prewar governors were state officials dispatched by the Home Ministry and subject to the command and supervision of the national government. However, governors in postwar Japan came to be publicly elected, and prefectures managed to acquire a character as local governments constituted by the political representatives of the people. Fearing that publicly elected governors would no longer comply with instructions issued by the central government, ministries indicated that they felt a sense of mistrust in these publicly elected governors. In this connection, the prewar system of agency-delegated functions under which mayors were seen as subordinate organs of the state and made to execute affairs of the state accordingly was expanded in its application to prefectural governors to ensure the execution of the affairs of the state by prefectures.

Second, administrative decentralization targeting municipalities acted in line with the strengthening of the role of municipalities as general administrative entities for a region. As has already been mentioned, the authority of municipalities over social welfare, health, sanitation, and education was reinforced due to Occupation-era reforms. However, the

number of municipalities during the 1940s rose to approximately 10,000, and it became difficult for smaller towns and villages to efficiently carry out the administrative tasks they were newly empowered to perform. In this connection, large-scale municipal mergers took place in the 1950s to increase the size of municipal populations and expand their administrative underpinnings.³ These major mergers of the Showa Period reduced the number of municipalities from approximately 10,000 to around 3500.⁴ At the same time, municipalities obtained a basis as entities capable of comprehensively providing social services. Consequently, the relationship between the central and local governments in Japan came to maintain an interfused character.

Third, in addition, fiscal decentralization also helped maintain the interfused relationship between the central and local governments. Despite an expansion of local taxes after the war, municipalities were not granted sufficient financial resources that could be considered consistent with their authority. For this reason, municipal finances were strained in the 1950s. In connection with this, the Act on National Treasury's Sharing of Compulsory Education Expenses was enacted in 1952 to develop contributions by the national treasury for compulsory education. The Local Allocation Tax Act was enacted in 1954 to stabilize financial coordination between the central and local governments. In these ways, the development of systems to guarantee the financial resources of local governments strengthened the financial basis of municipalities in particular.

Thus, the decentralization of power that occurred during the Occupation further strengthened the interfused character of the relationship between the central and local governments in Japan. On the other hand, amid increased demand for social services and an expansion of the administrative functions of both the central and local governments after the Second World War, the trend toward functional centralization that began in the 1930s persisted. In postwar Japan, however, the system of agency-delegated functions was also extended to prefectures, while the administrative and fiscal infrastructure of municipalities was upgraded through municipal mergers and the development of a financial adjustment system, such that an interfused relationship between the central and local governments through which local governments are comprehensively responsible for delivering local social services under the supervision of the central government was maintained rather than a separate relationship through which ministries of the central government provide services by setting up local offices for each type of social service.

3.3.3 *Central and Local Government Relations Under the Rule of the LDP Government*

The postwar relationship in Japan between the central and local governments remained stable under the longtime rule of the Liberal Democratic Party (LDP) between 1955 and 1993. The LDP government, which achieved high levels of economic growth that began in the 1960s, proactively promoted regional development in accordance with the idea of undertaking the *balanced development of national land*. Local governments also demanded the development of infrastructure based on a national land plan spearheaded by the central government and mobilized locally elected Diet members to lobby offices in charge of public works in order to obtain subsidies for public works. Under the long-term rule of the LDP, local governments pursued public works and regional development through political channels linking the central government and local governments and often engaged in fierce political competition to attract projects and obtain subsidies in a way that resembled the clientelism that can be observed in Italy and other southern European countries (Tarrow, 1977; Calder, 1988; Muramatsu, 1997).

From the latter half of the 1960s to the 1970s, the problem of pollution garnered attention as a negative aspect of economic growth in Japan, and governors and mayors who were supported by the Socialist Party and Communist Party were elected to form local governments in such metropolitan areas as Tokyo, Osaka, and Yokohama. These progressive local governments opposed the conservative rule of the central government and developed policies that emphasized the environment and welfare. As Japan entered a period of lower economic growth from the end of the 1970s, however, these governments were criticized for increasing the budget deficits of local governments and went on the decline.

Thus, while political dynamism in the form of opposition to the central government by prefectural governors and municipal mayors who came to be publicly elected as a result of the political decentralization that had been achieved during the Occupation era was observed during the 1970s, the interfused relationship between the central and local governments remained stable under the long-term rule of the LDP. Local governments attended to their own administrative duties as well as to agency-delegated functions under the direction and supervision of the central government on the assumption that financial resources were guaranteed by local allocation taxes and subsidies from the national coffers.

With respect to this relationship between the central and local governments under the rule of the LDP, it is recognized that local governments were given the latitude to exercise policy discretion and that the system was not always centralized (Reed, 1986). In addition, as mentioned earlier, it is a fact that competition arose between local governments to attract projects and obtain subsidies. However, the general framework of the administrative and fiscal systems governing the relationship between the central and local governments did not change throughout the LDP's long-term rule. In addition, a system of government ordinance-designated cities was set up as a special exemption for large cities in 1956. Although the number of government ordinance-designated cities increased throughout the postwar years, the two-tier prefectural-municipal system itself was maintained.

3.4 DECENTRALIZATION REFORM AND CENTRAL AND LOCAL GOVERNMENT RELATIONS

3.4.1 *Decentralization Reform Since the 1990s*

The stable relationship between the central and local governments that lasted until the 1980s underwent significant changes beginning in the 1990s when the period of LDP rule came to an end. With a falling birth-rate and aging society and the rise of globalization in the late 1980s, the belief that local governments should attempt to deal with local issues in accordance with local circumstances rather than have a uniform national response applied became the prevailing view in society. In addition, as administrative reforms were being advanced at the national level to deal with budget deficits from the 1980s onward, the idea of promoting the streamlining of the central government through decentralization alongside deregulation was put forth. Moreover, as part of the process leading up to the change of government that took place in July 1993 after revelations of collusion and scandals involving bureaucrats and politicians emerged at the beginning of the 1990s, it was argued that making a break with the profit-driven politics that was allowed to operate under LDP rule required, in addition to such political reforms as electoral reform and reform of the political funding system, a way to limit the powers of the central government through decentralization reform.

As a result, decentralization reform has been ongoing in Japan since the late 1990s. First, decentralization reform consisting of the abolition of the system of agency-delegated functions, the stipulation of rules governing the involvement of the central government in local government, and the establishment of a system for the handling of disputes between the central government and local governments was carried out based on the Act on the Promotion of Decentralization, which was enacted in 1995. Under this initial wave of decentralization reform, amendments were made to the Local Autonomy Act and other relevant pieces of legislation in order to ban the arbitrary involvement of the central government in local government and expand the freedom of local governments to make their own decisions.

Second, in addition to such examples of administrative decentralization, local tax and fiscal reforms to expand the independent financial resources of local governments and mergers of municipalities to strengthen the administrative and fiscal infrastructure of municipalities in response to decentralization were promoted at the beginning of the 2000s. Specifically, under the Cabinet of Prime Minister Junichiro Koizumi, a three-part reform package calling for a transfer of tax resources from the central government to local governments, a reduction of state subsidies, and a review of the local allocation tax was implemented. In addition, the great municipal mergers of the Heisei Period were undertaken to accommodate the promotion of decentralization, and attempts were made to expand the administrative and fiscal infrastructure of municipalities.⁵

Third, a second wave of decentralization reform was promoted from the late 2000s onward and involved a review of the involvement of the central government in local government and the transfer of authority by the central government to local governments. When local governments conduct their affairs, central government ministries sometime mandate methods and criteria for the execution of these affairs in laws and regulations. Under the second wave of decentralization reform, the imposition of mandates and frameworks by the central government in this manner was abolished or relaxed, and authority was transferred from the central government to prefectures and from prefectures to municipalities.

Thus, significant progress has been made in efforts to both administratively and financially decentralize Japan since the 1990s. When it comes to political decentralization, no major institutional reforms have been carried out,⁶ but it is believed that the political influence wielded by the heads of local governments, especially prefectural governors, has increased due to decentralization reform (Hijino, 2018).

3.4.2 *Characteristics of Central and Local Government Relations in Japan*

Decentralization reform changed the relationship between the central and local governments in Japan, but it also retained the following interfused characteristics.

First, decentralization led to the abolishment of the system of agency-delegated functions and a review of the involvement of the central government in local government, but the structure by which the policies of the state are implemented through prefectures and municipalities has been maintained. If we examine the administrative activities of the central and local governments in Japan in terms of net expenditures by purpose, we see that the areas in which local governments are not involved are limited to pensions and defense, and that local governments pay for a substantial portion of the costs of social services including school education, public welfare, and sanitation (Fig. 3.1). Administrative activities carried out by local governments in Japan encompass an exceptionally wide range of areas, such that the interfused relationship between the central and local governments is being maintained.

Second, large-scale fiscal transfers from the central government to local governments have occurred in Japan in order to guarantee financial resources to support such local government activities. Compared to OECD countries, the share of tax revenue accounted for by the central government is relatively low at 38.3% as of 2021, but the share of government spending accounted for by the central government is the lowest at 16.4%. Nevertheless, whereas the central government accounts for a greater percentage of revenue than local governments (24.3%), the opposite is true of spending, as local governments account for 36.3% of total government expenditure (Figs. 3.2 and 3.3). In Japan, national taxes are higher than local taxes at the tax-collection stage. At the same time, local allocation tax grants as a general fiscal resource and state subsidies as a specific fiscal resource are allocated from the central government to local governments, such that local governments play a bigger role than the central government at the stage where services are provided to citizens.

Thus, an interfused character maintained since the Meiji Period is incorporated into the relationship between the central and local governments in Japan, which is characterized by the scope and volume of activities carried out by local governments that are relatively large by international standards. If we look back at the history of the relationship between the

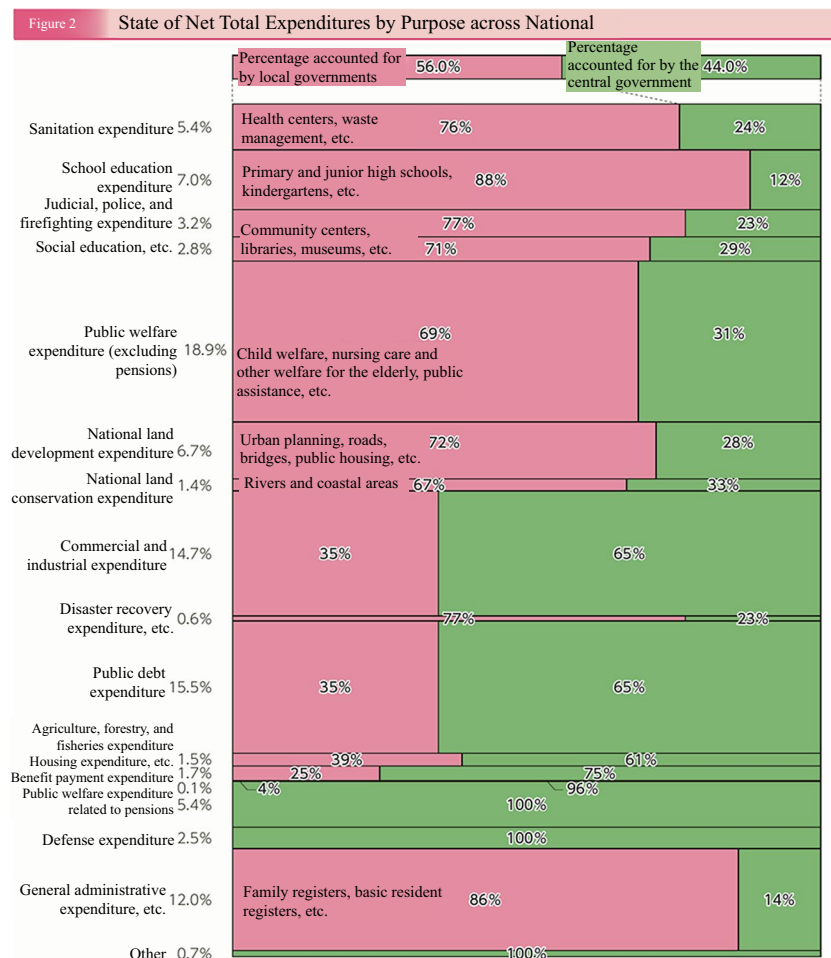


Fig. 3.1 State of net total expenditures by purpose across national and local governments. (Source: Ministry of Internal Affairs and Communications, *White Paper on Local Public Finance 2022*, p.4)

central and local governments in Japan, we see that, while decentralization was intensively attempted during two periods—the Occupation period after the Second World War and the period from the 1990s onward—the interfused relationship between the central and local governments has

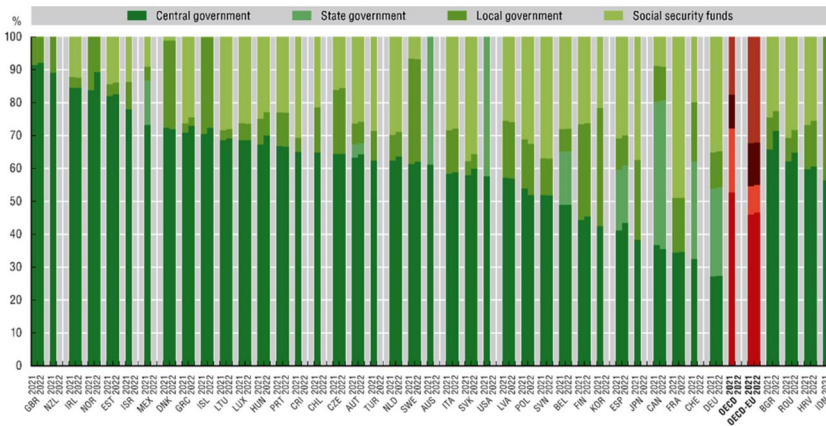


Fig. 3.2 Distribution of general government revenues across levels of government, 2021 and 2022. (Source: OECD, *Government at Glance 2023*, Fig. 10.7)

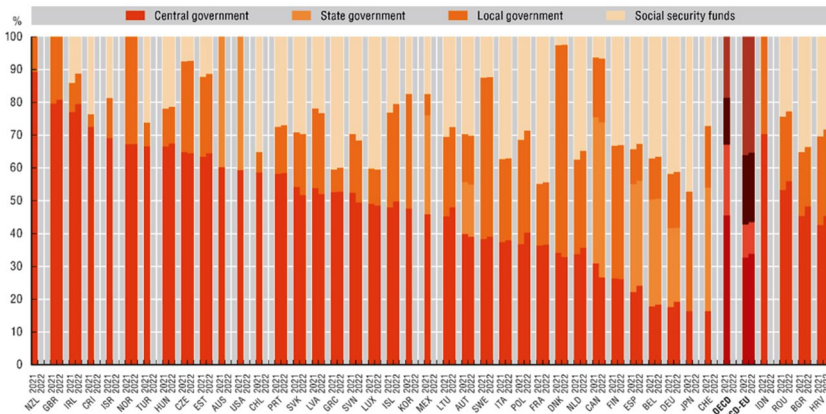


Fig. 3.3 Distribution of general government expenditures across levels of government, 2021 and 2022. (Source: OECD, *Government at Glance 2023*, Fig. 11.12)

been reinforced or maintained in administrative and financial terms. In order to grasp the characteristics of public administration in Japan, the significant role to be fulfilled by local governments cannot be ignored.

Conducting research into individual areas of public administration requires an understanding of the structure of the relationship between the central and local governments in each relevant area.

3.5 PERSPECTIVES FOR THE FUTURE

As has been made clear in this chapter, the relationship between the central and local governments in Japan was developed along with the formation of the modern state. While this relationship underwent centralization during the Second World War, we have been experiencing decentralization in terms of administrative, financial, and political aspects over a period of approximately 130 years. At the same time, the interfused relationship between the central and local governments that formed during the Meiji Period has been maintained to this day, such that local governments play a huge role in the area of public administration in Japan.

However, Japan has been affected by various crises since the 2010s that have been redefining the relationship between the central and local governments in this country.

First, major disasters, including the Great East Japan Earthquake that struck in March 2011, provided opportunities to rethink the roles of the central and local governments in crisis management and recovery. With the Great East Japan Earthquake, municipality-centered recovery efforts were advocated, and local governments in Japan were recognized as exhibiting resilience (Samuels, 2013). On the other hand, the Basic Act on Disaster Management was amended in 2012 to reinforce the coordinating authority of the national and prefectural governments as concerns support operations between local governments and wide-area evacuations.

Second, the COVID-19 pandemic exposed a lack of coordination between the central and local governments and between prefectural and municipal governments with respect to infectious disease control. Some observers have argued that the strengthening of the autonomy of local governments through decentralization reform led to inadequate responses to COVID-19 (Takenaka, 2020).

Third, Japan is faced with a crisis in which a declining birthrate and aging population are diminishing the sustainability of local communities. The trend toward centralization in Tokyo remains unabated, while the existence of communities in places other than metropolitan areas is threatened by a shrinking population. In a society in which the population is

shrinking, ensuring the sustainability of small local governments in particular is a challenge.

In order to address such crises consisting of large-scale disasters, new infectious diseases, and a shrinking population, the belief that Japan should restructure the relationship between the central and local governments and choose to go with centralization may gain momentum in the future. Alternatively, if depopulation were to progress to the breaking point, large-scale municipal mergers and a review of the two-tier local system may again be put forth for consideration.

In light of the history of the country to date, however, it is hard to imagine that Japan will abandon the interfused relationship between the central and local governments and pursue a form of governance that bypasses local governments. In other words, it appears inconceivable that Japan will move in the direction of separation of the central and local governments. Local governments will likely continue to play a key role in Japanese governance.

NOTES

1. About 1718 municipalities and 47 prefectures as of April 1, 2024.
2. The prewar Home Ministry enjoyed comprehensive jurisdiction over local administration and finances, the police, public works, health, labor, and religion (Shinto). From the 1930s onward, the Home Ministry harnessed the Special Higher Police to suppress communists and anarchists, spearheaded the Movement for General Mobilization of the National Spirit, and supported militarism.
3. For this municipal merger, a target population of 8000 people was set as the size of the population that can accommodate the affairs for which municipalities were newly responsible, such as junior high school education, social welfare, and firefighting.
4. In the process of the modernization of Japan, large-scale municipal mergers have occurred three times. The first was “the great Meiji merger,” which occurred at the end of the nineteenth century in line with the establishment of the municipal system of cities, towns, and villages. The second was known as “the great Showa merger,” as described here. The third was “the great Heisei merger,” which will be discussed later. The Meiji (1868–1912), Showa (1926–1989), and Heisei (1989–2019) periods refer to divisions of era in Japan as defined by the period of each emperor’s reign.
5. This municipal merger caused the number of municipalities to decrease from 3229 as of April 1999 to 1727 as of April 2010.

6. However, the *Discussion Forum Between the National and Local Governments* was established by law in 2011 to promote the participation of local governments in national politics; discussions between local government representatives in national associations and the relevant ministers are regularly held.

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